But You Were Magic to Me

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31789156.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F, F/M, M/M, Multi

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Kyle/Lonnie/Rogelio (She-Ra), Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Angst and Tragedy, Grief/Mourning, Childhood Trauma, Fluff and Angst, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Episode: s05e13 Heart Part 2, Survivor Guilt, Past Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Lesbian Catra (She-Ra), Lesbian Adora (She-Ra), Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Catra is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), POV Adora (She-Ra), Oblivious Adora (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Hopeful Ending, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Implied/Referenced Character Death, Implied/Referenced Suicide, Happy ending???, I dunno you'll have to read it and see, I apologize in advance to your hearts, It is a grief analysis but I also need you to trust me, look i'm not a monster okay, I promise, But it's gonna hurt the whole way through

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of We Come Alive or Come Undone

Collections:
Iorek's Catradora Unputdownables

Stats:
Published: 2021-06-07 Completed: 2023-01-31 Words: 18,701 Chapters: 5/5

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But You Were Magic to Me

by Poputchik

Summary

It should have worked.

They made it to the Heart. Adora woke up. They opened their hearts.

They kissed.

And then she was gone.

Catra had felt the weight of her - the warmth of her, in her hands. In her arms. There was a blinding light, and then:

Nothing.

No She-Ra.

No Adora.

Nothing but emptiness remained in the chamber of the Heart of Etheria.

After the kiss, Adora vanishes. Catra struggles to deal with the loss. She finds a book of letters that Adora has written to her over the course of their time apart (at the behest of Perfuma), and through them begins a journey to understanding the girl she loved and perhaps some self-discovery of her own.

Notes

This was initially intended to be a long series of short letters, but the more I write the more I realize there is a lot more to unpack, and a lot more in the way of how the characters can or would deal with grief and the loss of their lifelong love/best friend/hero. I am not entirely sure where the story will go, but I am so thoroughly in love with these characters and I hope I do right by them. This is also the very first fic I've ever written, and I apologize if I get some details or timelines wrong! I will do my best.

Addendum 28 Nov 2022: I know this fic has the MCD tag, but for those who have read RaptorRed's Drive, I need you to think of it like that - I need you to *trust* me.

See the end of the work for more notes

Alone, alone

It should have worked.

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They kissed.

And then she was gone.

Catra had felt the weight of her - the warmth of her, in her hands. In her arms. There was a blinding light, and then:

Nothing.

No She-Ra.

No Adora.

Nothing but emptiness remained in the chamber of the Heart of Etheria.

For Catra, there was only confusion. This wasnt what was supposed to happen. It couldnt have happened. Or if it did, it should have taken Catra with it. She wasnt supposed to be here *alone*. They were supposed to be *together*, whether that meant in life, or ...whatever else.

“Adora? Adora, please! You *have* to be here! *I BTB BCK ADA* -,”she choked, and in that space collapsed, the grief threatening to wash her away like an ocean tide. A hurt so deep and sharp she felt like she could feel her chest break open with each unwanted tremor.

So she laid there and sobbed until nothing more would come - until all that was left was to exist, unwillingly .

After an eternity, when her body had finally become something more like numb, Catra stood up, and walked out of the Heart. She felt hollow - like everything inside her had been scraped out and she was left moving only by rote - muscle memory the only thing propelling her to put one foot in front of the other. The light inside the facility was nearly gone, sucked away by the magic as it reemerged into the world above. The walls that had hours ago been so bright and colorful were left flickering only a pale, brittle half-light.

Catra's mind was a fog - a fugue state where everything around her almost seemed to melt together. She walked out into a world renewed - a world explosively awash with life. Trees, grass, animals - all of it had returned in a flash with the release of the Heart's magic.

For her, though, none of that mattered. Not the world, not Prime, nothing in the entire universe was greater than the chasm of emptiness inside her. And for as much as she wanted it to just swallow her up, and make her disappear, she was still here.

And so she walked - still one foot in front of the other, until she came to the field where the Etherians had made their desperate final stand against Horde Prime and his army of clones. Catra had no idea how much time had passed, nor did she really care. It had clearly been some time since the battle ended, as the newly grass-draped field sat mostly empty, devoid of the usual signs of battle - there was no damaged equipment, were no dead and wounded. What little remained were Etherians attempting to comfort and herd the distraught and scattered clones of Horde Prime - just more lost and aimless victims of a cultish dictator.

Everything seemed so far off, so unbelievably distant, until a muffled voice reached her ears:

"Catra? CATRA!"

The Queen of Bright Moon suddenly appeared in front of her, throwing her arms out wide and pulling her into a hug that would have been uncomfortable in the best of times - but now, Catra barely

registered the intrusion into her personal space at all. When she let go, Catra felt her knees begin to give, sheer determination the only thing keeping her standing. She needed to find somewhere to lie down before gravity did the job for her.

"Catra? Catra. Catra!" Sparkles was shouting, trying to break through the fog.

"Catra, where's Adora? It worked, Prime's gone! The magic destroyed him! She did it! She-Ra saved us all! Now where is she? Where's our girl?" she continued, excitedly.

"Yeah, we need to do a Best Friend Squad group hug!" Arrow Boy added, walking up to her side. She could *feel* him beaming with happiness, without even seeing his face. He placed his hand on Catra's shoulder and gave her a friendly squeeze.

Catra looked at the ground, focusing entirely on the grass that had grown up in an instant - green, and bright, and alive. *Alive*. Catra felt her face flushing, and fire glowing inside her chest.

"She - *she finally got what she wanted*," Catra growled, twisting her shoulder angrily away from Bow's hand.

She knew the words were a lie. She just wanted to push them all away. She wanted to be alone. She wanted...

She wanted those stupid, pale, blue eyes staring back at her again, proving that what she was saying was wrong. Those idiot eyes, always so bright and kind and...

She screwed her eyes shut, trying to force herself not to think about it. About eyes, about faces, about words. About anything.

It didn't work. It never could have.

She knew she had seen the truth of it in those eyes - knew Adora had found her value there, whispering those words to each other at

the end of the world.

[love you, too.]

"W - what?," Glimmer stammered. "*What does that mean?*" she pressed, her words cracking with anxiety, with fear.

"She's gone," Catra said. Dull, flat words that just seemed to fall out of her mouth without warrant.

Catra heard the sounds of their hearts breaking, and walked away.

*

The rebel camp was abandoned by the time Catra finally found her way back - everyone off celebrating, or dealing with clones, or going back to their own homes.

She found Melog curled up on her own sleeping mat, waiting patiently for her as she knew they would. They made a mewling sound and moved to allow her the space to lay down, and nuzzled their nose to her back as they lay down behind her. She lay curled up that way, facing Adora's empty sleeping mat, for what seemed like hours. She couldn't sleep, but she couldn't cry. Her body felt like a weight that she couldn't lift, destined to be stuck in this one place until eternity. The universe could swallow her up any time now, if it pleased.

She stared at the empty sleeping bag, zipped and made up tight, as only Adora would - she stared and she remembered the curves of Adora's face as she lay sleeping, bathed in the dim orange light of the camp. She pictured that ridiculous hair poof and ponytail, struggling to remain intact as Adora tossed, and turned, and fought invisible adversaries. Catra found herself wondering who exactly it was that Adora fought in those dreamland sparring sessions. Had it ever been her?

Of course it had. They had been enemies for so long, after all.

All that time - she had wasted it all.

The longer she stared, the more she wished she had done with the time she *had* gotten. She could have curled up beside her, wrapped herself around her, intertwined their fingers like they used to do back in the barracks when they were younger, back when they didnt know what their feelings meant. She imagined the ghost of Adora's neck, right there, inches from her face, and…

The dam she had built over the past few hours suddenly cracked, burst open, and Catra found herself on her knees, tearing Adora's sleeping mat to shreds, an outburst of rage and grief and pain so blinding to her senses that she almost didnt stop herself when she saw it.

As she stared down at the mess shed created, there was ...something. Something red, and sqare, and unfamiliar . She made herself reach for it, and what her hand came back with - was a book. A hard-bound notebook, bigger than any of the ones Adora had filled with notes back in the Horde, but bright red and emblazoned with the words DO NOT OPEN written in Adora's studious and proper handwriting on the front cover.

How had she not seen this before? She would have noticed Adora writing in something like this, would have seen that look of feverish concentration she always got when she started writing down notes or theories or tactics - so ridiculously *Adora,* and something Catra had always found absurd, but somehow shed never been able to look away.

Thinking about her now, and that silly habit of hers, her heart ripped open again, and she cried. She pulled the book in tight to her chest and let the tears take her.

When she awoke, it was dark outside. The lamps still bathed the inside of the campsite with a golden torchlight. No one had come back to the campsite in the time shed been asleep, or at least they hadnt stayed. She didnt care if theyd seen what shed done.

Catra sat herself up, propped herself against a supply crate, and focused her eyes on the notebook. It was harmless, right? Just some notes of Adora's. What was the point of even opening it? To satisfy some latent curiosity?

Or maybe to see what was so important that Adora had kept it secret, even from her.

She took a deep breath, and it was ragged - the way her entire body felt, and then:

Catra reached down and picked up the little red book, DO NOT OPEN, and nervously, defied it.

*

Catra,

It was suggested that I start writing letters to you in this book, as a way to work through everything. I don't know if it's going to help, but I know the Princess who suggested it won't let me hear the end of it if I don't at least TRY.

I know. Princesses. We grew up being taught to hate them, that they were destroying Etheria. But now… I know otherwise. And some of them aren't that bad. Like the one who told me to do this - Perfuma. You wouldn't like her, not at first. Her whole thing is flowers and meditation, and yours is… stun batons and blowing things up.

Okay. I'm not writing my feelings. She told me to write my feelings. So here goes:

I'm sorry, Catra.

I'm not sorry I left the Horde. I'm just sorry I left YOU. You're the only good thing about that place. My best friend. Even now, I know that. I miss our times on top of the Forge, looking out over everything. That

was our spot. Our time away from Shadow Weaver, Mirdak, and the rest of the cadets that you never liked anyway.

I just want to be able to have that feeling with you again. The way we used to be. The two of us together against the world. Why didn't you come with me? You said you knew that they lied to us, so why didn't you leave with me? I don't get it, Catra. I want to understand. I want to just TALK to you and… I can't. And it hurts.

I want you to be here, with me, so I can show you all the wonderful things outside the Fright Zone. There's so much beauty here, Catra. So much more than we ever got to see in the Horde. Like horses. Have you seen horses? They're just so... AHHH! And ABC! I want to share this stuff with you, so much. The big things, the little things, the stupid things. All of it. Just so long as you're with me. And I know you'd grow to love it as much as I do. One day I'll convince you to switch sides. You're a good person and your heart is so big, Catra. I will not give up on you. Even after you hit me with that stun baton.

I really miss you.

Love,

Adora

Kids, kids

Chapter Summary

> Catra gives herself a new mission, and makes a stop along the way.

A flurry of noises sounded in the emptiness of the camp that night - a sad, guttural cry, followed by a bang, a clank, and a flutter as a little red book sailed across the campsite and took a lamp with it on its journey down to the ground. Catra pulled her knees up to her chest and sat in a ball, her tail wrapped around her like that scared little kid she'd been far too many times - way back when. Melog raised their head inquisitively - they seemed to be having as much trouble understanding her emotions as she was. Right now she felt herself vacillating somewhere between "broken" and "on fire," but neither feeling seemed fully prepared to take hold.

Why had she expected anything else? What else *could* it be but a book of her words - *Adora's* words, written directly to her, during… During the time she didn't want to think about. Back when she had turned her back on Adora, because she had thought Adora had turned her back first. Back when she thought all she could do was hurt, because all she could do was *hurt*.

Back when she was so convinced that she could bring Adora back to the Horde.

How stupid could she have been? How blind? How selfish was it of her to try and bring Adora back to that hellhole? Someone like that… She didn't belong there. She never had. And it took Catra so long to realize. And so much pain. Hers. Adora's. The entire planet's. *Of course* the universe brought this book to her. All it had ever brought her was pain. Why not throw salt in the wound?

No, she thought, screwing her eyes shut again. This was Flower Girl's fault. If she'd never made Adora write the stupid thing, then Catra wouldn't be falling down, now.

She balled up her fists. She knew it wasn't true. Not by a long shot. But she needed someone - anyone - to blame, because the universe couldn't answer when she screamed in its face.

So it seemed like "on fire" had won.

*

As the sun came up that morning, Catra shoved the little red notebook in her pack, and set off to Bright Moon Castle, to find the Flower Princess.

*

"WHERE IS SHE?" Catra shouted as she slammed open the double doors to the Queen's quarters. Sparkles and Arrow Boy both reeled in surprise - startled out of their own grief-stricken reverie by the violent cacophony of her entrance.

Catra stood in the doorway, shoulders and chest rising and falling sharply as she caught her breath from her long-distance sprint to the castle. She hoped it made her look imposing. It probably didn't.

As the two of them regained their composure, her eyes flicked between them, sizing up which of them was more likely to answer her question, and which of them was going to be *totally* useless. Sparkles seemed unable to do anything more than sniffle through some hideously red and puffy eyes, so she turned to the smart one.

"Where. Is. She." she growled.

"Catra, she… Adora…" he stammered.

"NOT. HER. I thought you were supposed to be smart?"

Catra closed her eyes in frustration, and then raised a hand to stop the idiot from speaking further. Clearly he was just as useless.

"I'm sorry, it's my fault. I wasn't clear. Where is the *Flower Girl*?" she seethed.

"What? Catra," it was the Glitter Bomb's turn to speak, apparently.

Her brow furrowing in confusion, she continued, "Perfuma is helping Scorpia rebuild the Fright Zone. What do you want *her* for?"

She stood up from her seat and moved to put her hand on Catra's shoulder, but Catra recoiled. She didn't want to be *touched* by *anyone*.

"Catra, please. You can come here. We *want* you to," the Queen said, pulling her hand back and raising her arms in what looked like surrender. Or pleading. It was hard for Catra to tell with all the sniffing and shaking the woman was doing. "We need...we need to have a service. We need to do something for her."

Catra raised her head and pinched her nose in irritation. She felt the pit threatening to open back up, so she stoked the fire instead.

"The flower girl and I have *unfinished business,*" she snarled, turning her back to her - to *Adora's* closest friends.

"Do what you want. I won't be here for it," she said, and let the sound of doors slamming shut behind her punctuate what she assumed would be the end of her time in the kingdom of Bright Moon.

*

The Fright Zone. Of *course* the Flower Girl was there. She and Scorpia clearly had something, and the Fright Zone was Scorpia's kingdom. A total *fixer-upper* of a kingdom, to be honest. A lot of that being her fault, of course.

She walked along a meandering path through the woods just west of the castle, Melog keeping pace beside her. She couldn't make her brain just *shut up*, and the longer she walked, the worse it seemed to get. She wished it weren't so far to the Fright Zone - she wasn't the slightest bit interested in being alone with her thoughts for the amount of time it would take her to make the trip, but she had just blown her only other option up like a bomb. She could have asked Sparkles to teleport her straight to the Throne Room if she hadnt just cut them of f as they tried to reach out - if she hadn't just lashed out at them and pushed them away. And that's what it was, wasnt it? Lashing out was what she *did*. She had been working on it - trying so hard to rein in that particular survival tactic, honed through years of torment at the hands of her parental figure and countless leaders, besides. She had been working on it, for Adora. And now she was backsliding - and she wasnt sure if she could stop it.

The forest around her began to thin, and up ahead Catra could hear the sounds of civilization. As she got closer, and she could begin to make out houses, and shops, and people, something started scratching in the back of her mind. It was the ghost of a memory, a little voice whispering, trying to reach her. And then it hit her like a bolt of lightning.

Thaymoor.

Melog brushed up against her leg and she knew they had just taken her cue and magically rendered the two of them invisible. She stepped off the trail they had been following and crept closer, until they were at the end of the treeline, watching a clearing full of people go about the business of preparing for what looked like a fairly large gathering.

Thaymoor, the town she had once destroyed. The town where she and Adora had fallen out. Where it had all gone wrong. She wouldnt be welcome here. Likely, ever. But even if she wanted to go in the town, it held too many bad memories for her to even try. Hell, just seeing it from the outskirts was already sending those all-too-familiar pangs into her heart. But, maybe - no, she decided. She wouldn't go

in town, but she wouldn't leave. Not yet. Maybe the best she could do was sit here and watch - watch as the locals set up for what she could now tell was a celebration. A celebration of the end of the Horde, of Horde Prime, of the occupation. Maybe the best she could do was sit, and watch, and see if she could see what Adora had seen that day.

A thought struck her, then, totally unbidden.

That letter. What had it said? She hesitated to bring it out - it had already been a knife in her heart - but Adora had said something about that day. So she reached into the pack and, reluctantly, pulled out the little red book. With all the courage she could muster, she opened it to the first page, and read until she found what she was looking for.

Why didnt you come with me? You said you knew that they lied to us, so why didnt you leave with me? Idont get it, Catra. Iwant to understand.

She wiped a wetness from her eyes and thought back to that day, three years ago, when she felt like her world had ended. Why didnt she go with Adora? If you had asked her then, she couldnt have given an answer. Because she had been a kid - a kid who watched her best friend, the only person she ever felt *safe* around, take the side of two random people she had just met. People they had spent their lives preparing to fight. A kid who had watched the love of her life turn into the very thing they had been raised to hate - betraying everything they had ever known. Betraying *her*. And she had known even then what Adora truly meant to her - but she had been so stupidly terrified of ever admitting it. She had never cared that it was forbidden. She had never given a damn about the Horde's rules on relationships.

She had only ever been terrified that Adora wouldn't feel the same way. That she would reject her.

And that day in Thaymoor, she had *felt* that rejection, clearer than anything she had ever felt in her entire life. She had felt that feeling of her heart and everything else inside her being ripped apart, torn out. Hollowed. And so she spent the next two and a half years lashing out. Only her lashing out had the nasty little side effect of nearly taking the entire planet with her.

No one ever said she was *well-adjusted*.

She took a deep breath and looked up from the book, taking in the sights and sounds of the little town that had been the backdrop of that terrible moment in time.

The entire village was vibrant and alive - the smell of food, enticing and bewitching, wafting along with the breeze. Kids playing little kid games, people putting up tents, moving benches to cluster them together. Everyone laughing, smiling. Everyone *happy*.

On the other side of the clearing, Catra spotted them. Large, ambling, kind of stupid-looking. To Catra, they didn't particularly elicit the words "amazing" or "majestic." Maybe she just didn't see the appeal. But Adora had loved them. So she sat and watched and tried her best to picture how Adora must have looked the first time she'd seen these horses. The way she always did when she got overly excited. Her eyes always getting bigger than should have been physically possible, her words always stammering with excitement when the surprise was *good*. The way she had reacted when Catra gave her that stupid red jacket that she stole out of a Horde supply room, never giving a second thought to the idea that someone might ask *where she had gotten it*.

She let the tears fall, then, and turned the page to read the next letter.

*

Catra,

Look, this is hard for me. I'm not good at talking about my feelings. I've always been better at DOING things than TALKING about them. You know that.

Everything I've seen of what the Horde has done - after I left, of course - just proves to me that I did the right thing by leaving. The Horde leaves nothing but pain in their wake. How was I so blind that I didn't see it before? The way Hordak treated us, the way Shadow Weaver treated us, the way the rest of them treated us. They're not good people, Catra. They hurt people. They hurt US.

I never thought I'd have to fight the people I grew up beside, but here I am, swinging a giant sword at the tanks I was once taught to drive. Taking up arms against the people I trained with my entire life.

I'm just glad that you weren't out there that day . The day we met Perfuma (the flower princess), and made her people fight back for their own lives and their own kingdom. They were just going to give up and leave! They had never fought, not in their lives. These people aren't EVIL, Catra. They're the most peaceful and accepting people I've ever met in my entire life.

I'm glad you weren't there because [~~the words here are completely blocked out and written and shaded over, because the person writing this letter clearly didn't think to use a PENCIL~~]

Because I don't know if I can fight you, Catra. I know I don't want to. Ever . Just the thought of it makes me feel sick. Like my heart is upside down and inside out and I just can't take it.

Tomorrow we're going to Salineas, the sea kingdom, to try and get the Princess there to join the Alliance. Everything's happening so fast that I barely have time to think, let alone think about what I'll say the next time I see you.

I know what I won't say . I won't say I miss you.

Even if it's true every second, every minute, every hour, every day that you're not here.

I'll SOMEHOW [illegible] ,
CARA.

Love,

Adora

Time, time

Chapter Summary

> Catra continues her journey to the Flower Princess, and meets some friends - some new, some old.

Chapter Notes

> I apologize for the delay, but I had some real life stuff happening. Also, this one was really hard to write - there are two lines in particular that just broke me to write, and I had to take breaks.

The journey to the Fright Zone was beginning to feel like an endless nightmare. One minute it was fury and gritted teeth, forcing down violent outbursts, and the next it was weak knees and almost total collapse as some flicker of a memory would surface - an unasked question, a soft look, a word spoken in fear or faith. Sometimes a warm touch, others a scar from the heat of battle. All of it had Catra spiraling down, and down, and down.

Why did this walk have to be so long?

"Ohhh, Catra Dearie!"

The voice knocked her loose - stopped her being swallowed whole by the darkness in her head. Catra stopped and looked around in shock. She hadn't even *realized* she had entered the Whispering Woods. They looked... different. There was no sense of foreboding, no sense that the woods themselves were conspiring against her.

That was all coming from inside.

No, these woods were bright, and friendly, and inviting. She could swear she felt - warmth.

"*Catra Dearie*, what are you doing out here?" the voice crooned, and Catra turned just as a small woman with thick, round glasses appeared at her side and grasped her hand. "Come now, we have so much to do! So much to prepare for!" the old woman squawked.

Catra snatched back her hand and reeled backwards, confused and infuriated.

"Who are you? *How do you know my name?*" she said, her voice one step below shouting.

The woman paused, a look of concern flashing across her face, followed immediately by a look of deep thought.

Moments passed before the old woman spoke again.

"Oh, Dearie. If you don't know Madame Razz, then it must not be time, yet! No, no, not time yet," she said, looking Catra up and down as if she was searching for something. "Ah! You have it! Okay, okay. Catra Dearie, may I see the book?"

Catra couldn't respond. She could only stare at the woman, dumbstruck.

And then she was being repeatedly hit on the head with a broom.

"The book! The book, dearie! The book my Adora is writing! May I see it?"

Catra swatted the broom away and slowly unslung the pack from her shoulder, carefully opening it and removing the book. She pulled the book in tightly to her chest and held it there, as if to let go meant to lose it forever.

But why? Hadn't she, *just that morning*, slung it across the room in a fit of rage? Wasn't she on a mission *at this very instant* to go scream her fool head off at the girl who had sparked its creation? And now

here she was, clutching the little red book, DO NOT OPEN, like her life depended on it.

Her face scrunched shut with indecision, Catra was pulled back from her thoughts by a soft mewling from the direction of the old woman. Slowly, she opened her eyes and looked down - saw Melog brushing themselves against the old woman's dress, the calmest she'd seen them act with anyone - anyone besides Adora.

Sighing, she held out the book and the old crone snatched it from her, hurriedly opening it and rifling through the pages.

"HEY!" Catra *did* shout, then.

"Don't worry , Dearie," and then, "Ah, ha! Here we are! Okay!"

The woman placed her finger onto a page near the end, her look softening and her head nodding. She closed the book gingerly, handing it back to Catra only moments after she'd received it, like she had read it all and already figured out whatever it was she needed.

"Oh, my poor Adora. Such a sweet girl, that one. *So much* love to give. So much love for her *Catra*. Yes, yes. But you knew that, didn't you, dearie? Oh, you must go talk to her. She must know Madame Razz is *proud* of her," the woman said, as she began to sweep the forest floor.

Stunned, Catra found herself fighting for air, fighting to stop another breakdown. When she could finally speak, the words were rough, broken.

"Madame Razz? Adora… she's"…

"Gone? No, dearie. Not gone. Look *around* you! All of this *magic!* My Adora is not gone. Not as long as Etheria has magic! But if *I* wanted to talk to her, I would go to *where the magic is strongest*. Yes, that's where I would go. Now, off with you, Catra dearie! Don't you have a

mission to finish?"the old woman said, and disappeared into the forest, broom still in hand.

Catra stood there in that tiny clearing, hands shaking as she gripped the book, trying to hold back tears, trying to figure out what the *hell* had just happened. Trying to figure out how much of it was her own mind failing. Was she starting to break with reality? Or was it just the Whispering Woods playing games with her?

Finally, she shook her head, took a deep breath, and steeled herself. She put all thought out of her head beyond the next immediate physical action she needed to perform, and just *did that*. She placed the book back in her pack, and turned to find the woods ahead of her had opened up - so much so that in the distance, she could finally see it.

*

The Fright Zone

It was surprisingly beautiful, actually. The entire crater had been taken over by flowering vegetation, greenery that swayed this way and that with each tiny breeze - a stark contrast to the old machinery and layers of smog that had once been the kingdom's only inhabitants. The only inhabitants beyond the army of child soldiers that Hordak and Shadow Weaver had forced to do their bidding, of course.

Catra looked out over the expanse of the kingdom for long minutes, scratching Melog's ears and trying to build up the courage to take those last few steps. She thought of seeing her old home, thought of facing Scorpia. All of it made her uneasy - made her nervous. Some of the fire inside her had died down - for the moment, anyway. But that was far from a guarantee that she wouldnt chuck that insidious little book at the Flower Princess's pretty face the instant it entered her eyeline.

The thought made her chuckle, and Melog head-bumped the side of her leg in response.

With that, Catra grabbed the straps of her pack and headed down the hill into Scorpia's newly reclaimed kingdom.

*

As she reached the outskirts of the former Horde base in the center of the crater, Catra was astounded to realize that the place was *anything* but empty. Horde adults and kids alike were everywhere, patching holes, clearing away debris, being *productive.*

Being productive, and *smiling*.

And laughing.

There was an entirely different *feeling* about the place. It felt like… *optimism*.

She caught a few sidelong glances and pensive looks as she and Melog made their way further toward the center of base, but no one bothered them, and no one stopped them. In her periphery, she caught a fleeting glimpse of a familiar mismatched trio ducking into her old barracks building - a trio that she *shouldnt* want to follow, but the closer she got, the more she wanted *anything* to pull her away from the conversation she knew was coming when she met *Princess* Scorpia.

Maybe she should have thought harder about things before heading off on this "mission" of hers.

The main hallway of the barracks building was totally dark, but as she reached the halfway point, Catra could see light spilling out from the common room. And with that light came the faint sound of voices.

Why had she followed them in here? They *hated* her. And she deserved that. She just… What *did* she want? To see how they were doing? The last time they'd interacted, she had… She had hurt them. All of them. Physically, mentally. Emotionally. She'd sent them off to fight battle after battle after battle in a losing war, with no sleep, no supplies, no time to heal.

It shouldn't have been a shock, the realization that she was never any good at being a real leader. She had learned from the worst, after all. And they had left a *kid* in charge of an *army*. Idiots.

Catra reached down to Melog and signaled for them to turn them both invisible. Still she kept to the shadows, pressing her back to the wall as she crept closer and peered into the room.

In the common room, scattered among the couches, reclining chairs, and gaming tables, lay piles and piles of Horde armor. In one of the chairs sat Rogelio, taking stock of what looked like paint? In the center of the room, hunched over a table, was Kyle. He was painting something, but she couldn't quite make out *what.*

Images of Shadow Weaver and the other squad leaders flashed in Catra's mind, and the reactions they would have if they found whatever *this* was.

As she looked around the room, she realized something was missing. There should have been three -

"*Catra.*"

She and Melog both jumped at the sound of her name, their invisibility immediately falling away.

"If you're gonna sneak up on someone, it helps if you look *behind you*," Lonnie said from down the hallway , arms full of what looked like food. Not the staples of Horde kitchens, the gray and brown ration bars. No, Lonnie was carrying *real* food. *Etherian* food.

Catra started to protest, but Lonnie just bumped her shoulder as she passed, and said, "Come on. I think you oughta see this."

The two of them walked into the common room, Catra trailing nervously behind.

"Guys, look who decided to check in on us like it was *old times*," Lonnie remarked, nodding toward Catra. She stood just inside the doorway, purposely avoiding eye contact as Lonnie dumped their haul onto a nearby table.

"Oh, hey Catra!" Kyle said, trying his best to sound friendly, and to his credit, seeming *almost* like he meant it.

"Hey." she replied, feeling wholly unwelcome and *greatly* regretting her decision to follow them back here.

"Kyle," Lonnie said, "go ahead. Show her what you're working on."

"Oh! Yeah! Just one second, I'm *almost* finished with this one," he replied excitedly. He turned back to the table and went back to painting, and a few moments later, stood up triumphantly. He held in his hands a piece of Horde armor - the chest plate to a Horde combat suit, turned away from Catra. He was practically strutting as he brought it over to her, and as soon as he turned it toward her, she could see why.

What Kyle had done, and what Catra realized he had done to *dozens* of similar pieces, was paint over the Horde symbol that adorned the front of the standard-issue chest plate. In its place, in the brightest yellow-gold they could probably find, was a pair of *wings*.

Tears lined Catra's eyes as she looked at him, and for the first time, saw the person he had become. Tall, strong, and beaming with the earnestness of someone who had always just wanted to be *accepted*. Rogelio was standing now, beside him, his arm resting

gently on Kyle's shoulder. Behind them both, Lonnie stood arms crossed, chin up, projecting strength - and *pride*.

Catra wanted to be *angry* at them. They had never gotten along with her, and here they were *being nice* to her? They should have been yelling at her! She should be forced to fight her way out of this room! She wanted them to *hate* her. She wanted to yell all of these things in their faces, wanted to scream -

"Why?"

It came out a whimper, a sad question asked by someone who could do nothing but wipe her sleeves on her eyes.

Dammit. There was no hiding it now.

Kyle's smile dropped then, just a little, not because he was any less proud of his work, but because of what it meant.

"For She-Ra," he said.

*

Catra,

I don't know what to say to you right now. My heart is all screwed up. I want to yell at you. I want to tell you that I didn't leave you, Catra. I wanted you to come with me. The same thing I wanted to tell you last time.

Today, at the Sea Gate, I wanted…

I can tell you what I don't want.

I didn't want to fight you. And I guess I didn't. I just stood there while you punched me.

When you choked me.

When you clawed me.

We've fought before, in training. I know that. But this was different. This…

This hurt.

She-Ra can heal.

But I still feel your claws on my face.

You said Force Captain used to be the thing I wanted most in the world. That's not true, Catra. It never was. The thing I wanted most was ~~X~~

You still think I'm going to come back to the Horde.

I'm not.

I will.

*I [illegible] ALL
I AM [illegible]*

I [illegible] I AM [illegible].

[Here, the paper appears to have gotten wet somehow. There are some drops and a gap, and then]

You're the smartest person I've ever met, Catra. You think so far outside the normal tactics guides that they constantly have to put new rules in BUT to stop you from winning all the time.

I can't compete with that. I don't WANT to compete with that.

I don't WANT to fight you.

But I will if I have to.

But Catra, I am SO not giving up on you.

Today, at the Sea Gate, I wanted…

I wanted a few more seconds.

Love,

Adora

Hate, hate

Chapter Summary

Catra chats with an old friend, and finds the object of her ire.

Chapter Notes

This is one of the hardest fics to write. The first scene was written over a year ago. The second scene was written tonight, though I've had it in my head for a very long time.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Catra?"

Of course she ran here. Where else would she go? Running through tears, barely able to see - the muscle memory brought her back here. And Lonnie knew exactly where she would go.

She grumbled a sound in response - not words, just a noise, hoping it would make them go away. She'd curled up on an old bunk, staring blankly at a pair of children's scribbles, scratched and bittersweet as they stared back. A reminder of a time when two lonely kids found each other and decided that they were the only people they would ever need.

Was this what every day was going to be?

"That's a neat trick," Lonnie said as they slid down to sit beside her.

"What?"

"That thing back there in the hall. Going inv-"

"Since when does the Horde give a *damn* about She-Ra?" Catra interrupted, the question barbed in a way she didn't quite intend.

"That's rich, coming from you," Lonnie snorted.

"What the hell does that mean?"

"Just that we heard all about whose side you ended up on, there at the end."

Catra closed her eyes and rubbed the base of her neck, feeling for the scar. She hoped one day it would fade. Maybe if *that* scar could fade, others could, too.

"I was chipped. I wasn't *on* his side," she growled, teeth clenched tight.

"Whoa, Catra. I didn't mean *him*. I meant - damn," Lonnie hesitated.

"What *did* you mean then?" She was seething now.

There was a long pause, and Catra could hear Lonnie's breath speed up and slow down, as if they were fighting back anger. Which, of course, she would have deserved. Instead, what they said was:

"I'm… I'm sorry, Catra."

It came out rough, stuttered, as if the words felt heavy in their mouth and only came out through sheer force of will. Catra closed her eyes *hard*, fighting back tears.

"What do *you* have to be sorry for?"

"We heard what happened… with Adora," Lonnie answered, hesitating for just a beat before they said her name.

Catra rolled over and looked at Lonnie, fixing them with a hard stare before snarling, "DON'T. DON'T YOU DARE."

Lonnie's face flashed through a number of emotions then - confusion, anger, concern, and then finally, landed on resignation. Lonnie leaned their head back on the wall and sighed, the deep and

exhausted sigh of a person who'd been through hell and back, and only just realized that the path was nothing but circular, if they didn't try to *do something about it*.

"We're really pathetic, aren't we?" they asked, finally.

"Speak for yourself," Catra grumbled, sitting back, arms crossed, staring up at the bunk above her. She decided to map out the strings that made up the bottom of the mattress.

"I know it's not really - *Perfuma says* it's not our fault. We were 'raised without the proper tools', she says. I mean, she's smarter than most of the rest of these idiots, so she *could* be right. She says she can help, that we can learn how to interact with people in healthy social forms' or whatever."

Lonnie scoffed, shrugged, and continued: "But do you think maybe we'll always be like that? That Weaver and the rest of 'em got in too deep? That our first instinct will always be to fight?"

A few breaths later, Catra replied, "I don't know. I hope not. Adora didn't think so."

Lonnie turned to look at Catra then, but Catra kept her eyes hard focused on the process of mapping out the top bunk.

Catra took a deep breath and continued:

"Shadow Weaver screwed us up. All of us. Turned us against each other for… for *fun*. I think it was her favorite game, honestly. She even *died* playing head games."

She closed her eyes and forced herself to take deep breaths, before finishing her thought.

"She was good at manipulating people. She thought that was the best way to get what she wanted. But what did it ever get her? Abandoned by her *protege*, thrown out by Hordak, and dead without

ever seeing the power she always wanted. What she did left a kid in charge of an army, an army that I basically destroyed by being so bad at my job that I forgot the most important thing: to have an army, you need to have *soldiers*. And even I ended up turning my back on everything she ever taught us, anyway."

"You actually weren't that bad," Lonnie replied, after a long pause.

"What?"

"Well, okay. Don't get your hopes up. You were *really* bad at dealing with people."

"*Thanks*."

"Like, *really really bad.*"

"Yeah. I get it. You hate me. Was there a *point* to this, or?"

"Would you shut up and let me finish?"

Catra sank back into the bunk and waited.

"Okay . Yeah, you were bad at people. Tactically, though? You were *damn* good, Catra. I thought for sure we had the rebellion on the verge of surrendering more than once. I think the problem - the *biggest* problem - was that everyone knew your weakness."

"Oh, *really*? What-"

"Every single person in these barracks has known your weakness since we were *eight years old*, Catra. So imagine how fast the princesses knew it once she switched sides."

Catra gripped her arms tighter and replied, "Shut up."

"Don't kid yourself. You think you were the only ones who found that kind of thing in here?"

She opened her eyes and looked at Lonnie, completely at a loss.

Oh.

Oh.

How had she not seen it?

"Yeah. And look. Maybe we *should* hate you. I mean, we *did* resent you for a long time. Like I said: *Really bad at dealing with people.*"

Catra brought her knees in close, expecting the teardown she *knew* was coming. Her breath caught in her chest when Lonnie said, instead:

"We don't hate you, Catra. Especially not me. Not anymore."

Cautiously, more whispers more than words, she asked:

"Why not?"

"Because if I were in your shoes, I wouldn't have gone down the road you did."

Catra just stared, not even attempting to hide her confusion.

"I wouldn't have gone down that road, Catra. I would have been *worse,*" Lonnie said, their breath ragged as they fought down a show of emotion that was so far out of character that Catra could do nothing but stare.

A few seconds later, Lonnie continued:

"We were out there in the Crimson Waste when that heart-wearing weirdo's message went up. And we thought, *hell with it*, and we - we didn't run. We decided to fight back. We were fighting these bots right on the edge of town, and one of 'em - one of 'em *hurt* Rogelio. Hurt him *bad*."

Catra could just make out wetness at the edge of Lonnie's eyes, but she kept herself from reaching out. They had never had that kind of relationship, and likely never would. So she just kept listening.

"Rogelio almost *died*, Catra. Right there in the sand of that forsaken hellhole of a desert. That's when I saw it. I saw myself in that instant - saw who I was gonna be. I wouldn't have been *human* anymore, Catra. I would have been a monster, just a message of rage and fury and *violence* that wouldn't ever stop, not ever, until every single other person on Etheria knew how it felt to know that loss. And then Kyle -"

Lonnie choked on their own breath for a few seconds, and said:

"And then Kyle jumped in front of Rogelio and destroyed that stupid bot like it was made of paper. I've never seen anything like it. And *then* he pulled Rogelio back and helped me get him to safety so we could patch him up. I swear, that boy is *so much* stronger than he looks," Lonnie let out in a short, broken chuckle.

"So no, Catra. We don't hate you. Maybe we're not exactly *friends*, but we'll be here if you need us."

Catra took a risk, then, and reached out her hand. She laid her hand on Lonnie's forearm, a comforting gesture. Something so alien to her, and yet, Lonnie didn't pull away.

The two of them sat in companionable silence for a while - Catra had no idea how long. It didn't really matter. They both seemed to need it.

After a while, Lonnie stood themself up, and turned to head out the door.

"I know I never answered your question, but -" Lonnie paused, clearly turning a thought over in their head.

"Maybe you should just go talk to Scorpia," they finished.

Catra looked up, meeting Lonnie's eye, "Yeah. I will. Thanks."

"Take care of yourself, Catra. I mean it."

"Okay ," she answered.

"Oh, one more thing," Lonnie said, ducking their head back in the door. "That sparkly one? Shimmer? Shiner? Glitterella?"

"Glimmer?"

"Yeah, whatever. *Queen of Idiot Mountain* . She's been looking for you. You *might* wanna go talk to her."

"I'll think about it, thanks."

Lonnie just shrugged, and stepped out.

*

She found them in the old throne room, the one that the Horde had left to decay, murals cracking and fading with time. Scorpia was working to clear some of the debris around a mural of what appeared to be a younger version of her, flanked by two older people - presumably, her parents.

In a far corner, working on placing some greenery, was the flower princess. A renewed heat burned in Catra's gut, seeing the person who was the reason for this accursed *book* so close. She was so -

"Wildcat?"

Scorpia's voice was timid, startled, and slightly rough. The look on her face was enough to break Catra if she thought about it for too long, a mix of guilt and anger and resentment building inside of her that she redirected by staring resolutely at Perfuma.

"Catra? What can we do for you?" Flower girl's voice was sickly sweet, measured with the care of someone who knew intimately how

to repress their true feelings.

And that's what she was, after all, wasn't it? A barely contained well of rage that put on a bright smile and a pretty face to try and force herself not to let it all out, not to let it hurt the people around her, even if it was hurting herself to do it. Catra had seen it in the Fright Zone, when they fought with Scorpia. She had seen it when Perfuma confronted her about how she had treated her former friend.

In her mind's eye, Catra had pictured this meeting going differently. Had pictured herself slinging the stupid book and beaning the stupid plant princess in the head, venting her anger in the only way she knew how - making other people hurt.

But here, now - the little red book started to feel heavy in her hands, in a way that she felt might pull her down again, if she let it. And it would be *so easy* to let it. To wrap herself in the pain and shut out the world.

"I-" she stuttered. Her entire goal in coming here had been to confront Perfuma, to blame her for this weight. But was she really so different? They were both innately angry people, the only difference was that Catra lashed out with words and claws, and Perfuma buried it in talk of breathing exercises and rose petals, or whatever. Tea leaves, maybe.

"I don't know."

Scorpia crossed the throne room more quickly than her feet should rightfully have carried that huge frame, and stopped short of Catra, a look of apprehension flashing on her face.

"Do you - can I hug you?" Scorpia asked, and at the tenderness in her question, Catra *did* break. She nodded through tears, and felt herself swept up into a hug that was warm, and comforting, and way more careful than she'd ever experienced before. The book dropped to the floor, pages fluttering in the drafty air, but Catra didn't care. She sobbed in those big red arms for what felt like forever, that

endless pit of sadness erupting again, the tide finally slowing and her breath coming out in hiccups as Scorpia whispered softly into the top of her head.

"I've got you, Wildcat. I've got you."

As her tears mercifully came to an end, and she pulled herself back from Scorpia's embrace, she looked up into those big, bright eyes, and decided to just come out with it. A thing she'd been holding back since she found that note on Scorpia's rack, a thing she knew she'd have to face, one day. And it seemed like vulnerability was on the table, so today was as good as any.

"Why - why are you being so nice to me? I was so awful to you - you're supposed to *hate* me. It's what I deserve," she coughed through a swollen throat. "I don't deserve *hugs*. You should want to hit me, or something."

To her credit, Scorpia only looked horrified for a second, before her face turned into something more - caring.

"Wildcat, I could never hate you. I didn't see - well, I didn't *let* myself see what you were going through, and the way I reacted by trying to force myself into your life and force you to be who you weren't, or who you couldn't be - at least then, I mean - I'm trying to say that *I* should have been a better friend. Perfuma and I have been talking, and she's been telling me about this thing called consent-"

Catra's eyes flicked nervously to Perfuma, but she was quick to turn her attention back to Scorpia, holding up her hand to stop her from saying anymore. Stop her from trying to take the blame away from her, blame she knew she deserved.

"Scorpia, stop. Just - just, stop. I was a bad friend. You were right. And I'm… I'm sorry," she said, turning her attention to her feet, pretending the heat in her ears wasn't increasing by the second.

Off to the side, Perfuma coughed, and they both turned to look at her. Gently, she handed the little red book back to Catra, and smiled at her - a real smile, this time. A sad, genuine thing, and it hurt Catra's heart more than a little to know *why*.

"I think we *all* have things to work on. But we can start from somewhere new, and move forward together," she said, brushing her palm on Catra's hand, a quick touch that Catra assumed was meant to convey support. "I am sorry I judged you so harshly when we first met. It wasn't right of me to take one side of the story without hearing the other."

"Thanks," Catra croaked, not sure of what else to say.

"I see you found Adora's letterbook. I don't know how much of it you've read - I don't know what's in it. It's not for me to know. But I hope that it at least can give you some insight into her frame of mind for the past few years - maybe give you some closure," Perfuma said, carefully, evenly. She was clearly trying to avoid hitting directly on the topic. On why Catra even *had* the book.

In the end, though, Catra couldn't *really* blame her.

Because maybe she was right: Even if it did hurt, and every page felt like tearing open a brand new wound in her already-bleeding heart - maybe she could learn something about the girl she had loved.

A love so desperate that she had tried to break the world, and so deep that she had chosen to stay, down there, at the last.

A love that she knew she would feel through every heartbeat, until that, too, finally sputtered, and stopped.

Chapter End Notes

I'm working on this again, but I think I'm going to change the format, going forward. The next chapter may be the last, and it may be significantly longer. We'll see.

Endings, beginnings

Chapter Summary

And so we reach an ending.

Chapter Notes

You may have noticed some of the tags have changed. I also changed from past to present tense, sorry about that.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra stays in the Fright Zone for another few hours, talking with Scorpia and Perfuma. The echoes of her continuously breaking heart shudder through her every now and then, and Scorpia hugs her, and hugs her, and hugs her.

They talk about the plans for the former kingdom, and what they're going to do with the remnants of the Horde army. For their part, Scorpia and Perfuma are adamant that anyone who wants a home there, will have it, and no one will ever have the childhood that they had, being raised to fight for scraps, to tear each other down in hopes of some miniscule reward that only served to foster more resentment.

No, they reassure Catra, no one will grow up like that on their watch - and it is *their* watch, officially, now. Jealousy flares in Catra's gut, but she forces it back down. Forces herself to be happy for her friend.

It's late into the evening before the detail comes out - something Catra had not questioned, and Scorpia and Perfuma had somehow almost managed not to stumble into: Catra's been missing for *weeks*. The realization stuns Catra, and the knowledge that she didnt know stuns the rest.

"Time flows differently in the Whispering Woods," is all anyone can make sense of it, by way of Perfuma.

No wonder Lonnie mentioned Sparkles looking for her. But why would she go back? The way she left - no, they wouldnt want her back.

After all, she never belonged there. Not without Adora.

*

The orange and red glow of the rising moons is so familiar, up here on the old lookout. She knows this will be her last time here - it hurts too much to bear, an ache of a life lost to time and tragedy, an echo of a life that belonged to them both.

Thoughts of their last time here together scratch and claw at her, and she squeezes her eyes shut to banish them - push away the shadows that she knows will always follow her, hunt her, in her most vulnerable moments.

She fishes down in her bag, and pulls out something small, and green - it's not the original, but that doesnt matter .

It's not hers, and it's not Adora's, and maybe that's why it seems fitting - it was a role that they thought they so desperately wanted, and struggled their entire lives for, but in the end was never fit for the shape of them.

It fractures so easily underfoot, and Catra wonders if there's something to be learned there, too - for all of its technological superiority, the Horde was just as fragile as the people behind it. A scarred and pitiful witch, a crippled old man, and a heartbroken girl.

As she climbs down from the overlook for the very last time, she knows the old Force Captain badge will be lost to the sands of time, just like the legacy of the Horde itself.

God, she thinks, with the whisper of a smile.

*

She doesn't know what drives her to do it - what self-inflicting painful compulsion pushes her to make camp on the edge of the Whispering Woods, near the clearing that gives her access to the tunnel down to the Heart. She should want to be on the other side of the planet, but instead, she sets to work building a shelter here, of all places.

Every few days she makes a trip back to visit Scorpia and Perfuma, to get supplies in return for some menial work. She worries they'll slip and she'll be on the receiving end of a shower of sparkles and an angry Queen of Bright Moon, but that particular nightmare never seems to come.

She works on building her cabin far enough from the edge of the woods that a stray passerby wouldn't see her , but close enough that - well, she's not sure yet. Close enough.

During the day, she works on building a garden, or learning to bake bread, or one of a hundred other things she finds to fill the time, to keep her mind occupied.

She lives her life in that time - the time between the pages. The moments she feels awake, and alive.

The rest of her time is an interstitial movement of liminal spaces, because at night -

At night, she reads.

And at night, she breaks.

Page after page of love and loss and regret consume and wrap themselves around her, folding her in and doing their best to drown her.

But in the morning, she always wakes to find her breath again.

*

If anyone asked, she'd say she didn't know what caused it - what finally sent her over the edge.

And if anyone asked, she'd be lying through her teeth.

Every page in that forsaken book is a jackhammer , punching through Catra's heart. For the most part, they're written like desperate pleas, the love of her life wishing she could break through, and reach her.

Still others are typical Adora - babbling about a new meal she tried, a new animal she'd seen. Minor things that brought her a happiness nothing in the Fright Zone ever could, at least in those small, casual ways. Written as if Catra had been going to defect the very next week, and Adora couldn't wait to show her all the little things in their new, exciting life outside the cacophonous machinery and oppressive environment they'd grown up in.

Every one of those letters is another knife, another scar that she'll wear for the rest of her life, but they're not what does it:

There's one page.

It's nearly incoherent, stained with what are obviously tears - half the words are scratched out, and the bottom of the page is torn.

But Catra can make out one word.

One word that picks her up and shatters her into a thousand pieces:

Portal.

*

Catra doesn't remember leaving her cabin.

Doesn't remember walking through that old, broken place.

Doesnt remember stepping over the ashes of the woman who was supposed to be her mother.

Doesnt remember going to the Heart.

She doesn't remember, and she doesnt *care.*

The Heart itself is empty - motes of light flicker and float, but theyre barely more than dust.

Catra looks up at that cold, dead thing, and does the only thing she can think to do:

She screams.

She screams at the Heart, for taking her entire world away.

She screams at Adora, for leaving her here alone.

She screams at the girl she used to be, for every moment shell never get back because she was so fucking *broken* that she decided to burn the world, instead of *losing*.

She screams, because in the end, she lost everything, anyway.

*

Melog wakes Catra in the morning, having curled up next to her where she fell. They walk her back to the safety of their new home, and a new routine begins.

*

Catra stops reading. She doesnt want to know , to feel, whatever comes next.

Every day she works around the cabin, working on this or that, busying herself, and every night, she goes back to the Heart.

She doesnt always scream.

Sometimes she begs, and pleads, for whatever magic will listen in Etheria to give Adora *back*.

On her darkest nights, she begs for it to take her, too.

*

Catra loses track of time, because what does time mean, at this point, anyway? Days, weeks. The woods dont care, why should she?

So she doesnt fully know how long it' s been, when there's a soft *pop* outside her door, followed by a slow, careful tapping.

The moons have just set, and Catra sighs as she realizes she' s about to have to make dinner for three.

She opens the door slowly, afraid of whatever nightmare energy or barrage of screaming awaits, but to her surprise, it's just Glimmer , alone, quietly holding a small basket and wearing a soft, sad smile.

Catra feels the defensiveness drain out of her shoulders, feels the familiarity of the situation - except this time she' s not the one bringing an offering, and she's not a prisoner. Well, not really. Though she figures some might consider a self-imposed exile and life under a pall of unrelenting grief to be a prison unto itself.

Without saying a word, she pulls open the door. The Queen waits, hesitating, clearly unsure if she's overstepping, but Catra gives her a small nod, and she enters.

As she passes, Catra catches a whiff of something familiar - something warm, and inviting. Something Sparkles made as a peace offering after their last shared experience with tragedy . She tenses as she remembers those days, how she couldnt stop lashing out, even after everything.

She lets out a long breath, and closes the door. Glimmer doesn't say a word, just takes a seat at the little bench Catra's made out of an old tree (thanks to some books and tools lent to her from the library of the former Fright Zone), opens the basket, and sets it gently in the middle. She takes one of the dumplings for herself and waits for Catra to do the same, though there's no insistence in her eyes.

Catra's shoulders drop slightly, as she concedes, and sits on the opposite end of the bench. She carefully takes a dumpling of her own, and without so much as a glance to the Queen, takes a bite.

It bursts with flavor, and she fights back tears at the memory it brings - Adora, smiling, expectantly, so genuinely *happy* to be eating together for the first time in years. Happy to see Catra offering something like vulnerability.

She doesn't want to cry, not here. Not in front of Sparkles. So she distracts herself with a question.

"What did you say these are called?" she asks, keeping her eyes purposely away from her dinner companion's.

"Bao. They're an old family recipe," Glimmer responds. Her voice is calm, and while Catra can tell she has things to say, things to ask, she holds them back, and Catra is thankful for it.

They eat in silence for a while, Catra relishing the taste of something that isn't entirely vegetables and bread, and Glimmer, watching Melog as they preen in the center of the room, on one of the rugs that Scorpia gave her.

Finally, she asks the first honest question that comes to mind:

"How did you find me? I'm nowhere near any walkable paths, and I didn't bring my tracker pad. Anyone I've been in contact with has promised - promised not to give away my location," she says, looking up to face the Queen. The look on her face isn't readable.

Everything she says is measured, even. Not quite clipped, but it's clear to Catra that she's forcing down a lot of emotion as she speaks.

"We looked for you for weeks. Sent out search parties. Made offers to any former Horde soldiers, just to find out where you were. And then one day we were visiting the Scorpioni Kingdom, and -"

Catra scoffs. "Of course. Scorpia told you didn't she? Can't keep a secret to save her life."

Glimmer raises her hands, palms up, and continues, "It wasn't Scorpia. At least, she didn't tell us where you were. But obviously, I was a mess. Bow was a mess, it - look. All she told us was that you were alive. And safe. And that you needed space, and time. So we gave that to you. It hurt - a lot."

Catra winces at the realization that she had caused Adora's - *her* friends more pain. In the white hot anguish she felt after the Heart, she hadn't cared. Had built herself an armor of barbs and fire. Had stabbed at their hearts and burnt her bridges. She balls her hands into fists, and feels her claws digging into the palms.

Could she *ever* stop hurting people?

"It hurt, but we trusted that Scorpia would know better than us what you needed, and as long as -," Glimmer's voice choked, "as long as you were alive, we decided we would have to live with that as the best we would get, and let you decide when to come back to us. If you ever did."

Her voice lilts downward as she plows forward, "But then we started getting reports."

"Reports?" Catra feels her face scrunching in confusion.

"Yeah. Reports from people who decided to explore the ruins of the Heart and the surrounding First Ones' facilities - *against my express*

wishes, I might add - that they could hear someone screaming, somewhere down deep in the facility at night. And then yesterday, this one," Sparkles waves her hand toward Melog, "shows up on our doorstep, and won't stop yowling until we follow them."

Catra's eyes flick down to Melog and she growls, "*Traitor.*" They just flap their ears and go back to preening.

"I think they were just concerned. You've been gone a long time, Catra, and I think they were asking for help."

"It's only been a few weeks," Catra snaps, frustrated that anyone could want her to let it go, to *move on*, that quickly.

The Queen takes a sharp breath, and Catra turns back to her. There's a look of surprise, and a deep, cavitous concern is etched into every feature of her face.

"Catra, you've been gone for almost six months."

*

Catra recovers, eventually, but she spins out long enough for Glimmer to make tea. It's the dark, chocolatey smell that finally brings her back to reality, and at this moment, she's thankful for her.

Time flows differently in the Whispering Woods.

How had she not noticed the passage of time? Not noticed the seasons changing? Or did those not matter here? She feels her grip on the tea cup tightening, a swirl of questions careening around inside of her head, threatening to pull her back down, when the Queen finally speaks.

"That's - that's another reason I'm here," she starts, her voice timid and measured. "We wanted to do something."

She pauses, eyes wary, but it's clear she expects something back from Catra, and- and Catra blows out a long, deep breath, reaching

in with everything she has, to ask, "What does that mean?"

Glimmer's eyes soften, and she answers, "We wanted to do something to honor her memory. We weren't sure what, yet, but we felt like - like it was important that she be remembered. *Always*."

Her voice cracks on the last word.

Catra wants to scream, to yell that she's not *theirs* to honor, that Adora is more than just a *memory*, but she knows that it's just that ball of darkness and hurt that she keeps hidden behind her heart trying to break free, to spit its own pain out at the world.

She sighs, and the anger washes away. She's been staring at the tea, watching the swirl of the liquid between sips, letting herself latch onto it, because being here and feeling all of *this*, feels a lot like grabbing an anchor when she's drowning.

Slowly, she turns her eyes up to Glimmer's, and she sees those same emotions, reflecting right back at her.

They're all stuck in the same boat, just hoping to survive the storm.

"Okay," she whispers.

*

Bright Moon is essentially the way she left it, if more populated than the last time she was here. Glimmer takes her around, showing her the options. A statuary outside of the castle, a garden plot in the middle of town, the base of the moonstone tower.

None of them seem *right*, but Catra can't quite decide why.

Maybe it's because none of them capture the meaning, the power of She-Ra.

Maybe it's because none of them can live up to the depth of the sacrifice behind their new world.

Or maybe, it's because none of them are as big, as deep, as humble, as effortlessly and easily beautiful as Adora herself.

Catra spends a week wandering the grounds, and the outlying city, by herself. Bow and Glimmer had offered to come, but she needed the time to herself. They had been nothing but gracious and hospitable since she'd come back, though she assured them it wasn't for long.

They had been expecting that, of course. But she could still tell it hurt them a little.

Maybe one day she could come back for good. One day when it felt like this place wasn't haunted in every corner, when it felt like Adora's ghost didn't wander through the cracks and the alleyways everywhere she looked.

One day.

For now, she'll settle for searching for the perfect place to honor the girl who saved the world - who saved *her*.

She wanders the outskirts of town, somewhere between the castle and the mountains, lost in her own head but still aware of her surroundings, when it catches her eye.

And it's *perfect*.

*

"Catra - it's *beautiful*," Bow says, his hand tight on Glimmer's shoulder.

Catra can't help but let a smug little smile show, because she knows.

The waterfall isn't large - at least in volume, in width. But it's *tall*. It seems to stretch all the way to the top of the mountain, the tallest peak beside Bright Moon Castle. And the pool at the bottom is clear, and sparkling, and *pure*. The wooded area that surrounds it means

it's mostly hidden, but there's a small enough trail that anyone who cares enough to visit will have no trouble reaching it.

"I figured we could put something here," she says, looking away when she sees they've both turned to look at her. It's still hard, after all this time, to be open about things like this. About anything, really.

But she tries.

And so she continues, "Maybe a small statue, or something. A plaque. I don't know."

Glimmer's voice is bright, and clear, "Catra, it's amazing. There's no other spot in Bright Moon that measures up. And maybe - maybe we could do something, just for us, too."

Catra flicks an ear and turns to face her, curious.

"I don't know - I thought maybe we could each find something that symbolizes-," the Queen's voice hitches, and Bow's hand shifts to her back, rubbing in small circles. "-symbolizes how much we loved her. What she meant to each of us, you know? And put them behind the waterfall? Where only we would know about them."

It feels right. It feels like the perfect idea.

And it also feels like drowning, again.

She forces the words out before her throat stops working.

"Yeah, that - that sounds good, Sparkles. I know just the thing."

And she does.

She just doesn't like what she's going to have to do to *get* it.

*

They give her space. They give her *a* space to inhabit, while she does what she needs to do. The things she needs to do here on Etheria and - well, elsewhere.

And yet.

Catra is hesitant - to enter this room. Glimmer and Bow are beside her, but it's like she's the only person in the universe right now, because this - *this* was where Adora slept for 3 years without her. Without the space for her, at her feet (or beside her, like they used to sleep, feeling the rhythm of each other's breaths, until that one, awful night when Shadow Weaver found them).

She knows they're there for her , and will catch her if she falls. It's a concept she's still struggling to understand.

But she has to do it.

Has to go inside.

Because who is she, but the one who Adora wore on her sleeve, every day, on every mission, in every late night conversation? She's written into every memory Adora ever had, and she knows it, because they've told her. Over and over again.

She didn't believe it at first.

Couldn't.

Because how could Adora still love her, in the middle of a war?

And that's what it was - *love*. That blinding and painful thing. That thing that reaches deep into the heart of you and wraps your insides in its grip.

Maybe they both tried to hide it, but here - it was clear Adora had failed. At this *one* thing, she'd failed.

And Catra is thankful, in a way.

But it still terrifies her to enter the room. Because her heart can only take so much. And seeing the space that Adora inhabited for so long, with no memory, no scent left to remind her of Catra - it devastates her to think about.

But she has to do it.

And the door slides open.

*

Catra notices three things, after she sits down and allows herself to process her surroundings.

Number one is that of *course* Adora used what amounts to an ornate military cot for a bed.

Number two is the blade she finds nestled under the pillow, which brings with it the realization that even here, Adora never felt truly safe, and Catra feels a quick flash of anger at the violent roots of their childhood, and the deep-seated fears it instilled in them both.

Number three is something Catra had never, ever expected. *Could* never have expected. The sight of it sucks the breath from her lungs, and her body moves on autopilot, the rest of the world shut out beyond her tunnel vision and shaking legs, as she rises from her seat on the bed and walks to a dresser on the other side of the room. Dimly, she's aware of Bow and Glimmer's curious stares, but they dont matter - not here, now , in this moment.

It's a smooth, perfect circle - a brilliant blue that matches a pair of eyes Catra will never stop seeing, every time she closes her own. She picks up the stone and clutches it to her chest, and she feels the tears burning down her face at the same time she feels herself wrapped in the careful embrace of the two people she blamed for so long, for taking Adora away from her. And she knows now that it wasnt them - it was so many things, but it wasnt *them*. Truthfully,

she knows there is no universe in which Adora doesnt leave, and she doubts there is any universe where she doesnt stay .

She wishes it could be another way, but that's not the way the universe works, is it?

She lets them lead her to the bed, where they sit down with her as she cries, heart crumbling at the memory she grips tightly in her hands.

"Do you want to tell us about it?" Glimmer asks, qietly .

The old Catra - that bitter, angry, spiteful version of her, would lash out. But again, she pushes back against that ball of darkness, and nods.

Her voice is scratchy, and wet, when she's finally able to speak.

"I didnt - I had no idea she kept this," she whispers.

"What is it? I mean we knew it had to mean something, since it's like, the *only* thing she brought with her that wasnt a knife or a sword or the clothes on her back," Bow asks, voice gentle.

Catra wipes away the tears and opens her hand to stare at the treasure that rests in her palm.

"W e were - thirteen or so, I think? I dont really know , we didnt keep records like that in the Horde. We had this little place that we would scrounge through - we found it when we were really little, and it was just a pile of rocks, mostly , but - one day Adora found this. It was the most beautiful stone in the entire place, and she offered it to me. I told her she should keep it, because-" Catra coughs, struggling to keep her voice. "-because it matched her eyes."

*

It turns out, the memorial and its public unveiling are going to take months to build, carve, and plan. Catra helps where she can,

sketching ideas for a statue - life-size, not some exaggerated nonsense thing. She struggles, because drawing any version of Adora hurts, but in particular because she wants it to accurately represent her - not just what the rest of Etheria saw, but the girl behind the symbol. She wants it to show her for who she was - She-Ra, savior of Etheria, and Adora, brave and silly and kind. Fierce, and mischievous. Awkward, and bubbly, and a light in the dark for everyone who knew her.

While she works through idea after idea, both on paper and in her head, she starts getting to know the other princesses.

Not willingly, of course. Not at first.

But they keep popping up in Bright Moon, and she isn't trying to hide.

At first, she expected them to show her how much they hated her, now that Adora wasn't around to vouch for her. She expected them to treat her like the monster she'd tried to be, back before the fall of the Etherian Horde. Back before the fall of *her* army.

On Netossa's third invitation to tea, she finally accepts. She's not quite sure *why*. The woman had only had a quietly antagonistic relationship with her before, but something in her eyes sparks her curiosity. And so she goes.

Netossa takes her to a balcony, a sitting space that overlooks one of the courtyards, and when they arrive, Spinnerella is already seated, waiting. On the small table before her there are three cups and a tea kettle, as well as a few mixers for flavoring. As they arrive, Spinnerella stands up with a sincere smile, and reaches out her hands in greeting.

"Oh, hello, Catra! I'm so glad you finally decided to join us!" she beams, and the sincerity in her eyes makes Catra's anxiety spike, but she returns the greeting and takes the seat they guide her to.

"Uh, thanks," she mutters, still unsure of why she agreed to come. Dont these people hate her?

When Netossa scoffs and says, "If we hated you, we wouldnt have invited you to tea, kid," Catra realizes, very uncomfortably , that the woman can see right through her - that she's too observant for Catra's own good.

You should, she thinks. *You should hate me with every fiber of your being, because Im a monster* .

She thinks these thoughts, but she doesnt speak them out loud.

Instead, she asks, simply, "Why?"

She can feel her tail lashing behind her at the looks on their faces. Spinnerella looks concerned, almost pitying, and she hates it. Netossa looks… pointed, like she's irritated at Catra for asking something so inconvenient.

"Oh, baby , no. I dont know what' s going on in that head of yours, but that's not how we do things here," Spinnerella' s voice lilts, softly.

It just confuses Catra *more*. She can feel her face screw up like she's trying to figure out a particular complicated tactical evaluation scenario.

"What she means is, there' s no room for hate here. Were we enemies for a long time? Yeah, sure. You did a lot of bad things," Netossa says, voice hard. Catra flinches at her words, but she doesnt try to argue. "But that' s war. It makes good people do bad things. Especially if it's the only life they know."

There's a feeling bubbling up in Catra's stomach that she cant describe, riding the coattails of the woman's words. "You think Im… good?"

She can't help the waver, the crackle in her voice. But she can barely hold to *hope,* and so she couches it, letting out what's been eating at her the entire time she's been in Bright Moon - the entire time she's been here and no one has reacted to her presence the way she expected them to.

"This is because of - of me and Adora, down in the Heart, right? Because of She-Ra. Because She-Ra saved Etheria," she asks, and she knows, she *knows,* she sounds like a child. Sounds broken, and sad, and - desperate.

Netossa's eyes are steel, and they're aimed right at her. It feels like she can see right into Catra's soul.

"*Screw* Etheria," she says, the words hot and sharp, like a knife stabbed at the universe. Spinnerella sets a hand on Netossa's wrist, and some of the fire cools, but it doesn't burn away.

"Kid, you gave me back my *wife*. When things were at their darkest, *you* told me not to give up. That she was still in there. Without you-" she stops, and takes a breath, seeming to find her center. "Listen. The whole Princess Alliance appreciates what you've done since you've been back on Etheria. Some more than others, sure. But to me - if *anyone ever* tries to get to you, or even so much as coughs in your direction, they've got to go through *me*."

"And me," Spinnerella says, and she's wearing a smile, but behind it, Catra can see the ferocity. "You're family now, Catra. Whether you like it or not."

*

Gradually, Catra lets herself open up. It's not easy, and it's not quick - it's not even something she *intends* to do, but inch by inch, she makes progress in exploring the parts of Adora's life that she never got to see. The parts she thought she never *wanted* to see.

Her social energy reserves are small, and she can only handle so much at a time, but slowly, carefully, she gets to know some of the other residents of the castle.

Glimmer and Bow are the same as they ever were, though they're careful not to push Catra more than she can take.

Juliet always keeps a wary and watchful eye, but seems to afford her a bit of respect, likely owing to her own status as a military commander, though Catra is certain she is far better with her people than Catra ever was. She is also, as it turns out, a talented artist, and joins Catra on some of her brainstorming sessions for the memorial statue, after stumbling upon her sketching in the gardens one day.

Frosta may not technically live in the castle, but she clearly spends more time here than in her own kingdom. She's loud, and brash, and altogether prickly, and Catra can see a bit of herself in her - maybe if she had been raised somewhere other than a nightmare factory in the shadows of monsters. But despite the appearances she puts on, she seems to be smart, and caring, and willing to see beyond Catra's past. At least enough to teach her about her favorite game, and her over-the-top self-insert character, Winter's Bane.

Micah, well - Catra avoids Micah. She would probably avoid Glimmer too, except they've already come to an unspoken understanding. They'll talk about it - one day. One day when Catra's heart isn't so fractured, the wound still so raw. When she's not one bad day away from being dragged into the abyss.

But she doesn't have three months in a white light prison uniting her with Micah, the terror of an unknown future and the bitter, unending loneliness building a thread to tie them together.

So she avoids him, ducking out of the way when she hears the familiar plod of his boots, or the timbre of his voice.

And it works.

Until it doesnt.

It’s one of her bad days - a day she thought she could force herself to open up the book and read again, but every time she tried, her heart beat to crack her chest, and her breath just wouldnt come.

So she had run up to one of the castle’s highest turrets - the valley staring up at her, rivers sparkling in the light of the moonstone, the moonstone itself gleaming down at her, softening the darkness of the night.

It’s there that she’s sitting, fighting the shudders and struggling to get her breathing under control, when she feels more than hears the air around her change, a soft breeze and the crunch of boots on stone as Micah sits down beside her.

And the air in her lungs is suddenly on fire, her mind racing for a way to escape - to get away before he can tell her how much he hates her, how much he doesnt want her here. That she’s reaping the consequences of her actions.

“Angie and I used to come up here, you know?” he says, and something in his voice makes Catra’s mind stop. The lightning that’s etching fractal patterns through her brain ceases.

He pauses for a beat, giving Catra time to respond, but she cant make her mouth do anything. She wants to shout, to scream that she *knows*, she *knows* it’s her fault, and she doesnt belong here and -

“I know you’ve been avoiding me,” he says, but there’s no anger, no accusation or deep and unabated hatred lacing the words. If anything, he sounds - worried. “I just cant figure out *why*. I know you fought for the Horde, but all of that is over. There’s no need for there to be battle lines. There *is* no Horde, no Rebellion. Just people. You know that, right?”

She turns to face him, and his eyes are already on her, but the only thing she sees is concern.

And she doesnt know *why*.

And it burns, deep down inside her. It burns that he can be so nice, after everything she's done. After what she *took* from him.

Catra has been doing her best to force down her old, destructive impulses. She really, *truly*, has.

But this? It's too *much*.

And so she stands, balls her fists at her sides, and turns the burning into fire.

"*Why? Because I took it from you! Because it's my fault she's gone, and I'm here, and-*" she screams, and her body shudders, and her footing - slips.

And she's falling.

And maybe that's what she deserves, after all.

But she doesnt fall. Not far.

Before she can fully make sense of what's happening, she's back on solid ground, two great big arms wrapped around her.

She cant help it, cant stop it. The words flow out with the tears, wracked with a guilt she's carried for years, now - one that's plagued her sleep, haunted her waking hours. Her voice is jagged, and broken, as everything falls out of her.

"I- I shouldnt be here. It should be *her*, not me. It's not *fair*."

She doesnt dare look up, keeping her eyes pinched shut as Micah holds her close. "Kid, do you really think you dont *deserve* to be here? That the world would somehow be better without you in it?"

She cant speak, not again, so she just nods weakly into his chest.

His voice reverberates through her as he speaks, "It's not about what you deserve or what you don't deserve. That's not how the universe works. I know you probably expect me to hate you, or be mad at you, or want you gone, or any number of things that a spiraling mind can think up, but - and this is important - *none* of those things are true. And do you know why?"

She gives a small shake of her head, and he continues.

"Because Angie wouldn't want any of that for you. She'd see you for who you are - a girl who made a mistake, because she wasn't equipped *not* to. A girl who helped save the universe," he says, the words carrying a finality to them that tells her he won't accept an argument.

"The girl who saved my daughter."

She pulls back, and he loosens his grip. She looks up at him, at the conviction in his eyes, and she can *almost* feel the words are true.

"We are not the sum total of our worst actions, Catra. We are who we try to be in the *wake* of them," he whispers, and Catra falls back to his chest and lets his breathing steady her own.

They stand there like that for longer than Catra cares to guess, before she finally speaks again.

"If Sparkles finds out about this, I will hunt you down. You know that, right?"

To his credit, Micah doesn't so much as chuckle as he answers. "I know."

*

By the time the official memorial comes around, Catra has gotten somewhat used to the overwrought flourishes and fanfare of Bright Moon and its residents.

She's surprised, then, that they let her wear her regular clothes - "Horde-chic," Glimmer had called it - but no one even implies that she should wear anything else.

The statue that's been carved doesn't have her influence - in the end, she'd decided that there was no way the images she and the Etherians saw when they thought of the girl who saved their world would ever fall into sync. As much as she's grown to accept that She-Ra was a part of Adora, in her mind, the two are so distinct as to be incongruent - irreconcilable.

So she'd left the design to Juliet, and what the woman had come up with *is* impressive. And maybe it surprises Catra, a little, that Juliet knew enough about Adora to capture some of that easy, slightly cocky confidence, so that even in She-Ra form, there's still a familiar thread of *her*.

It's big - a few feet taller than Adora was, even at full She-Ra height, and it's intricate. It's She-Ra, in full regalia, one hand cocked on her hip, the other gripping the sword, slung across her shoulder, a broad smile playing across her features that seems to want to tip upward into a smirk.

The ceremony is long, and there are a lot of stories told, but Catra never leaves her seat on the makeshift stage they've built. Micah, likewise, doesn't get up to speak, and though she'd never admit it out loud, she's thankful for his presence at her side.

Glimmer had offered to let her speak, to say something to the crowd, but she had quickly turned that down - for as much as she was making progress, trying to speak to her grief in a public setting was something that she knew she'd never be able to handle.

As the ceremony ends, and the crowd files out, Catra finds herself lingering behind, staring up at the visage of the embodiment of love - a love that stretched across three different dimensions, now.

She knows she should cry, or at the very least *say* something, but nothing comes.

Maybe it's because this memorial is for the Etherians as a whole.

Maybe it's because this memorial doesn't really reflect the life of the person it's meant to lionize.

Maybe it's because this memorial isn't for *her* Adora.

Sure, she feels a little of that neverending swirl of emotions that roils and rages in her gut - the pride, the sadness, the anger, the love, the loss.

But mostly, she just feels *blank*.

And that feeling scares her.

*

The three of them wait until dusk to do their own ceremony - nestled in the cave behind the waterfall, illuminated by Glimmer's magic.

They stand in front of the plaque, silent but for the rush of water ahead of them. The hilt of the former Sword of Protection hovers above the words carved deep into the bronze plate, held aloft by some form of magic that Catra isn't privy to, not that it matters.

None of them moves to speak, and it's clear to Catra that they are all wrestling with the weight of the moment.

The weight of "good-bye."

Which, Catra thinks, isn't really what this is, for her. She has other plans for that, but for the here and now, she can feel the anxiety filling the space, the tenseness in the set of their shoulders, and the grit of their teeth.

She decides to break it, whatever this is, by stepping forward and coming to rest in front of the memorial.

She lets herself drop, carefully, to her knees, and reaches into her pocket for the thing she's brought - that tiny piece of Adora that was a piece of Catra and will now be a piece of Adora again, for as long as it rests here. She shivers as she opens her hand and stares down at the smooth, deep blue. The eyes that it matched so closely flash in her mind and she has to bite down a sob.

Which, in a way, is a relief, because it means she still *feels*. The fear that gripped her at the Etherian memorial dissipates as she places the rock below the floating hilt, just above the plaque.

She sits for a few moments, willing her heart to remain in her chest, focusing on those two blue ocean eyes as they stare back at her from the shadow of the stone.

Slowly, she picks herself up, and steps back.

The anxiety of the space seems to have vanished, too, as she watches Bow step forward and place his memento down.

It's a little figurine - one they've told her he made initially for their war table battle plans, but came to use for board games instead. Sword held aloft, She-Ra stands two inches tall and mighty, and Catra finds herself compelled to ask, "Why She-Ra?"

Bow doesn't look at her , but she can tell he's struggling - to hold it together, to find the words.

When they do come, they're wet, and slightly broken.

"I wanted to keep the other one," he pauses, and Catra sees the heavy rise and fall of his shoulders as he breathes a series of deep, steadying breaths, "Because that way I could keep *Adora* with me, you know?"

And Catra's heart *breaks*, because she *knows*. And she would have known all along how deeply these two cared, if she'd bothered to *try,* that bitter voice that dwells in the back of her mind tells her.

Deep down, she knows there's no way things could have played out any differently, but still she feels that familiar seed of guilt trying to plant itself in her psyche.

So she refuses to water it.

"I know ," she says.

Bow and Glimmer trade places, and it catches Catra by surprise when Glimmer places down two, separate items. With one hand she places an ornate lantern, that she then uses magic to ignite, and turns slightly to Catra.

"It' s the lantern from my coronation," she says, by way of explanation, and Catra ignores the sting at what it implies, "when Bow and Adora helped me forge my connection to the Moon Stone. I couldn't have done it without them."

And sure, Catra may have been curious about the lantern, but what's got her head stuck in full friction lock is the small plate of food that Glimmer has placed down with her other hand. When the words finally come, she's aiming for nonchalant curiosity, but she can feel the nervous edge that rides the words out.

"Is that from your-" is all she says before Glimmer turns her head back and finishes the sentence for her.

"Our perfect day , yeah," she says, and though Catra *hears* the words, and processes them, her head is an electric fog. There's something-

"*I need Adora.* "

*

Catra is 3 years old.

She's learned, throughout her life, that showing weakness, being vulnerable, *gets you nothing.*

Nothing, except more pain.

Because she's smaller than the other cadets, she finds herself the butt of their jokes - the target of their ire, whenever they *get punished, and they need to feel in control again.*

She's fought some of them off, and that usually keeps them away for a few days, but before long, the memory of Catra's claws fades, or they just come at her in a group, and there's nothing she can do to stop them.

Adora would stop them, if she knew. Stop them for good, probably.

But then they'd know *she was weak. That she needed Adora to protect her.*

And weakness is pain.

So she's taken refuge in a supply closet, after running across nearly the entire training complex, and she's fighting back the tears that she hates, hates, hates that she can feel building in her eyes.

Secretly, she wishes that Adora wasn't in tactics class, that she-

The door clicks open, and Catra freezes.

"Catra?" a voice asks, warm and timid. Because of course *she managed to find the one random closet in all of the Fright Zone that Catra's turned into a momentary sanctuary - a dark, quiet, and safe harbor in the violence and the machinery of the only world she knows.*

She wipes the forming tears away and the answering words snap out of her - less at Adora, or her intrusion, and more at the timing of it.

What do you *want?*

The bite of her response doesn't deter Adora - it never does*, but she* is *careful as she responds.*

"I just needed to make sure you were okay-" she all but whispers, but Catra, always a tangled braid of thorns and poison barbs, cuts her off like a knife.

"I'm fine."

"Okay, but- I heard some of the other cadets talking, and-"

"And what*, Adora? You thought you would come and do what?* Protect *me? She wheels around to face Adora, the old familiar acid filling up her lungs, "I don't* need *you to protect me, Adora, I-"*

The words crumble between them as Adora quietly offers her a - a thing*, is all Catra could call it, because it's wrapped in one of Adora's old compression shirts. Poorly, but enough to obscure the item within.*

Startled out of her anger, Catra reaches out and pulls the thing to her, slowly unwrapping it, as Adora speaks, "I found this in an old supply closet in the back of the classroom I was in today. I was looking for some boot-shine, but-"

Her words trail off, but Catra isn't really paying them any attention, anyway. Instead, she's captivated by the thing that sits in her hands - a solid crimson plate, with sharp angles, vicious curves, and what look to Catra's eyes to be an artistic interpretation of fangs*.*

She looks back up at Adora, but she's too stunned for words. Adora seems to notice, so she continues, "I mean, it's armor, right? It's a mask. It wouldn't fit me, but you - with this armor between you and them, no one can hurt you."

Suddenly she turns sheepish, turning away and nervously rubbing the back of her neck.

"Do you like it?"

It takes Catra a second to get the thing to sit right on her face, and it's still a little big, but she can't fight the sharp grin growing on her face. She doesn't even want *to.*

"I love *it."*

*

So Glimmer doesn't like the plan. And truth be told, Catra can't blame her. Enlisting Entrapta and Bow to fly her back to Prime's ship is probably the last thing Catra herself expected to be doing.

But there's something there that she needs to find.

*

They're wearing their space suits, because Entrapta says the root system that embedded itself into the ship when the Heart of Etheria was activated has broken all of the life support systems. Surprisingly the artificial gravity still seems to be working, so they're not left struggling to fling themselves along.

Entrapta has stayed on the ship, but Sparkles and Arrow Boy have decided to join her.

Which, if she's honest, helps.

Because this is *not* where she wants to be. There's motes of light, leftover sparks of magic, floating everywhere, and there's plant life on almost every surface, but underneath it, it's-

It's stark white. And every flash of it unsettles her.

The search for the - the *room*, isnt a short one. Catra's memory is good, but a lot of what she remembers of this place has been altered, or the memory itself is just too jagged for her to grab hold.

When they finally reach it, it's random - they turn down yet another aimless corridor, and it's bathed in a faint, green glow.

The glow isnt the same as the rest of the ship - it' s unsteady, wavering and flickering, painting everything in a slimy sort of half-light.

Catra feels her muscles tense up, her legs rooting themselves in place, her body refusing her will to move.

She feels the panic rising in her stomach, burning a path to her limbs, to her head, to her brain.

And then she feels a touch, at the small of her back, and suddenly the panic recedes. It doesnt vanish, not completely , but it becomes a faint hum, a background noise that she can filter out. She looks to her left, and Glimmer gives her a small smile.

The look on her face is a question, *Are you okay to keep going?*

Catra nods in response, and the three of them push into the room.

It's not like she remembers it - once cavernous and sinister, a great auditorium to demonstrate the power of Prime's cleansing font, the room now seems dull, flat. Even the water, while it does still glow, has lost its malevolent radiance.

Catra lets out a ragged sigh of relief that the room - the place where she had her entire personality stripped away in liquid fire, no longer seems to hold any power over her.

They split up, hoping to lessen the amount of time spent, but as the minutes tick by and no one has found anything, Catra's heart sinks.

t has *to be here.* If it's not, then she's lost everything she ever had of-

She's startled out of her spiral by the snap of Glimmer's fingers, echoing sharply throughout the chamber.

"What? What is it?" she asks, because it's evident that Glimmer hasn't found anything, but she looks like she's got an *idea*.

"Do you remember the trophy room?"

*

"Of *course* it's here."

"Of course. Trophies were his *thing*, and you were-"

"I was the first *Etherian* he conquered," Catra spits. She wants to latch on to the anger, to the horror and the awfulness of the memory, but it slips away as she stares up at the thing hanging on the wall in front of her.

And she remembers nervous hands and whispered assurances.

"With this armor between you and them, no one can hurt you."

It's the voice of a ghost that wraps itself around her as she falls to her knees, desperately clutching the only thing she has left of it. Of her.

*

Catra's next few months are different - she doesn't spend all of her time in Bright Moon, nor does she spend it all in her cottage on the edge of the Whispering Woods.

Instead, she travels.

She visits the other kingdoms, one by one, but more often than not she just wanders Etheria, letting herself take in the sights of the world Adora saved. The world she rebuilt.

She comes and goes from Bright Moon in between trips - to have tea with Netossa and Spinnerella, to play games with Frosta, or to have dinner with Glimmer and Bow.

Every once in a while, she'll find herself on the tallest turret of Bright Moon Castle, Micah sitting peacefully by her side.

And she thinks, *this could be what it is to be happy.*

*

When she leaves, she doesn't tell them. She hugs them goodbye, like she normally would, with the assurance that she'll be back soon.

She wishes she didn't have to lie, but if they knew, they'd try to stop her. They'd tell her that people need her *here*, that they love her and want her around.

And she knows they would be telling the truth - at least their version of it. But really, no one *needs* her here. Etheria will keep its orbit long after Catra is gone.

*

She and Melog make their way through the woods, the path winding its way before them, when a familiar broom swipes in front of her face. Thankfully, she's quick enough to dodge, and she gently grabs it to prevent any further attacks on her person.

"Catra, dearie! The book!" the old woman squawks, and Catra sighs.

"Hello to you too, Razz," she says, pulling her well-worn backpack down and reaching inside.

A year ago, she was nervous to hand the book to the old woman, but today she knows better. Razz grabs the book and opens it to the last page, scans for a few seconds, and slaps it closed, before gently handing it back to Catra's waiting hand.

"So today is the day , isn't it dearie? Today's the day it happens!"

Catra knows she'll never fully understand Razz, but she thinks at least she has a handle on this.

Today is the day. The day she leaves Etheria.

The day she continues Adora's mission.

"Y eah, Razz - it is."

*

So maybe Catra didnt finish reading the letters. She wants to feel bad, but at the same time, she knows the rest. They didnt speak for almost a year, and the world almost fell apart, because she and Glimmer both couldnt handle the pain of rejection.

And then Adora saved her.

And Catra knows her heart will never fully heal - knows that when she thinks of Adora, shell think of the time *Catra* tried to be the one to save *her*, and she failed.

So maybe she didnt think she needed to read them, and she' s at peace with that. But down here in the remains of the Heart of Etheria, Catra reads over her *own* letter, as if she needs to proofread it before putting it in the mail. Or maybe she just thinks Adora deserves that much.

*

Hey , Adora,

I miss you. It's been a year, and I still struggle every single day with the weight of you being gone. Some days are easier than others, but the feeling never really goes away.

I know you said you were sorry you left me, and maybe for the longest time, I blamed you. I wanted you to hurt the way you made me hurt. Because I couldn't see past my own pain.

I can, now.

You were the best friend I ever had. When we were kids, you were my hero. When you left, I couldn't see how selfish I was being. I should have known you'd be a hero to so many more, but I wanted to keep that all to myself.

These friends of yours - well, I guess they're mine now, too. But they all knew you as She-Ra, Protector of Etheria. Ancient warrior made of magic beyond what anyone can understand.

But Adora, I knew you.

Plain old Adora. Blonde-haired, gap-toothed, blue-eyed, idiot Adora. And she was more than enough for me.

The rest of Etheria knew you as this magic symbol of something greater.

*But you - **you** were magic to me.*

Love,

Catra

*

Catra takes one last look at the Heart of Etheria, kneels down, and places the little red book DO NOT OPEN on the ground beneath it, in the center of the chamber.

She stands and slings her backpack over her shoulder, the movement accentuated by the weight of the mask that hangs prominently from it.

With a heavy sigh, she brushes a mote of familiar magic dust off of her nose, and makes her way to the surface.

The dust swirls restlessly behind her.

*

Catra doesn't stop to take so much as a final look out the cargo bay door as she slaps the switch to close it. If she's going to go, she has to go *now*, before her stupid heart can tell her she'll miss it, miss *them*, too much.

She's inventoried.

She's packed.

She's had Entrapta teach her how to fly.

Now she just has to leave.

Just her and Melog going out to the stars, seeing the universe and the magic that it has to share.

Just what Adora would want her to do.

And it's fitting that she'd do it *now,* on the one year anniversary of the Heart. The one year anniversary of her heart breaking into something she doesn't know if she'll ever fully recognize.

But she'll try.

They trot to the control room, and she touches the panel to initiate Darla's systems. A brilliant purple sphere appears in front of her, and cheers, "Hello, Catra."

She says another silent thanks to Entrapta for putting her into Darla's mainframe.

"Hey , Darla. I think it's about that time," she says, and she can feel how thready her voice is, feel the nerves in her skin burning as she builds up the courage to do it. To do this one final thing.

She looks down at Melog, and they give her a purr in return, a brilliant blueish-purple hue filtering throughout their body. It soothes her, just enough.

She's strong.

She can *do* this.

She turns back to Darla, and wills the words from her lips.

"Darla, take us up."

She waits - waits for the rumble of the ship leaving the ground, for the change in the force of gravity on her body.

Nothing.

She knows what it feels like when Darla lifts off. She's been onboard for take-offs and landings multiple times now.

So she knows something is *wrong*, before Darla even speaks the words.

"Negative, Catra. I am unable to fly at this time," the voice comes, dispassionate and even, and she finds herself seething at the lack of emotion. Because she wants to *scream*, but what's the point?

So Catra grits her teeth, forcing her claws not to dig into the console, and asks "And why *not*, Darla?"

"I cannot take of f with the cargo bay door open."

And-

That cant be right. She *knows* she shut it behind her. Maybe the sensor is broken, and shell have to get Entrapta to fix it, or-

Or Sparkles and Arrow Boy have found her.

Of course. Of course they wouldnt let her just *leave*. Theyll have to make it a whole *thing*.

Her ear flicks when she hears a boot step into the doorway behind her.

She raises her head, and Darla speaks.

"ADMINISTRA TOR DETECTED."

Chapter End Notes

I started this story to process my grief at losing the only other person who was a survivor of our specific shared trauma, and I had intended for a lot more.

But as you can probably imagine, this story was very, very hard to write.

I stopped asking for beta readers, because the content of the work was too brutal for me to ask that of my friends (though I have subjected a few to snippets here and there).

I ended this the way I did because I believe that fiction, while we can use it to process and understand our own feelings, can also serve as a way to write the happy endings we might not be able to have, in real life.

I apologize to all of your hearts, and I hope this ending doesn't feel rushed, or forced. I have planned for it to end this way for at least a year. I just had to force myself to *write it*.

Thanks for reading, y'all.

End Notes

Thanks to Lotty, Toki, TSGPod, Tara, and everyone else who gave me advice or input!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!